



STATUS REPORT

Somalia — digital transformation and data governance status report

Edition of 2026-08-21 • compiled from the Data Landscapers source base

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Somalia's mobile network is one of its few genuinely improving national systems and its internet is not: [Mobile Communications](#) is the country's tenth best-scoring indicator on the Ibrahim Index at 45.0 out of 100 in 2023, up 20.8 points over the decade and among its ten most improved measures, while the same scorecard puts [Internet & Computers](#) at 21.9 out of 100, 43rd of 54, on a decade gain of just 6.1 points. The broader [Infrastructure](#) sub-category scores 21.5 out of 100, 49th of 54 and below the African average, having moved 6.4 points in ten years.

About 27.9 per cent of the population used the internet in 2024 on ITU data, and [unique mobile subscriber penetration](#) sits below 40 per cent, well under the raw subscription count that multi-SIM ownership inflates. The gap is no longer mainly one of network reach. [Hormuud](#), the dominant operator, said in June 2026 that its 4G network covers more than 70 per cent of the country while around half its own subscriber base still uses feature phones, which makes the handset, not the mast, the thing standing between a Somali and the internet.

Satellite has filled part of the rural gap since [Starlink](#) was licensed in April 2025, and [AstaanConnect](#) became the first official Somali reseller in September 2025, selling and installing locally on plans from \$36.90 a month. Fixed capacity lands at Mogadishu, Berbera and Bosaso, but outside the cities last-mile electricity supply constrains what any of it can serve. Traffic exchange inside the country runs through an exchange point in Mogadishu operated by SomaliREN, active since 2018.

Two pieces of technical governance moved in 2026. The [National Communications Authority](#) is accelerating national migration to IPv6 under a strategy adopted in February 2025, ahead of IPv4 exhaustion, and in June 2026 it opened, with the IFC, Somalia's first [Submarine Cable Landing Technical Working Group](#), meeting in Nairobi under the IFC [Broadband Infrastructure Project](#).

Data Storage

The Somali government says its own data sits abroad. The Ministry of Communications and Technology stated in April 2024 that the National Data Center then being built in Mogadishu would ["eliminate dependencies of national data on international data storage solutions, that is stored outside the country"](#), and repeated the rationale in May 2025. That is the clearest official statement of where the country's public records physically are, and it is an admission rather than a plan.

The facility meant to change it has been a long time arriving. It is intended as the central repository for the data of all government institutions, and the minister described construction as nearing completion after a site visit on 6 May 2025, urging the implementing company toward timely and high-quality delivery. Fifteen months later, on 7 August 2026, the State Minister for Communications described the centre as planned rather than built.

Onshoring is therefore a stated aim with nothing behind it in law: Somalia imposes no data localisation requirement and instead runs an adequacy-based cross-border transfer regime under the Data Protection Act. Nor is there a domestic hyperscale option — no hyperscale provider operates a region in Somalia, the nearest availability zones being in Bahrain, the UAE and Qatar. The one independently tier-certified facility serving the country is Wingu Africa's carrier- and cloud-neutral Tier III data centre at Berbera in Somaliland, commissioned in 2021, outside federal jurisdiction.

Where onshore capacity has appeared, it has come from suppliers and operators rather than from the state's own build. Pakistan's NADRA delivered data centre infrastructure for the national identification system in March 2025, a facility separate from the government centre, and NIRA holds enrollees' fingerprints and facial images in a centralised database at the Authority's own data centre. Hormuud says it is investing in solar-powered data centres inside Somalia.

Energy

Power in Somalia is not scarce so much as unaffordable: electricity averaged about USD 0.61 per kWh in 2023 and exceeded USD 1 per kWh where supply came from private diesel micro-grids, against roughly USD 0.15 in Kenya and USD 0.06 in Ethiopia. That is among the highest tariffs on the continent, and it is the number that decides whether a data centre, a tower site or a clinic terminal can be run at all.

Around 50.3 per cent of the population had access to electricity in 2023, and the national figure hides a split that maps directly onto the digital divide: the National Bureau of Statistics reports urban access of around 79 per cent against 23.9 per cent in rural areas for 2023, a gap of some 55 percentage points. On the Ibrahim Index, Access to Energy scores 26.0 out of 100 for 2023, 37th of 54, and has moved 0.5 points in a decade — one of Somalia's better placings, and one of its flattest trends.

Supply is still overwhelmingly diesel, with solar and other renewables a minority of generation in 2023. The policy response is off-grid: the Ministry of Energy and Water Resources is developing a National Mini-grid Policy and Regulation with UNDP and GEF support through the Africa Mini-grids Programme, while deployment proceeds through projects including an AfDB-backed solar and grid programme in Bosaso. Reliability is measured hardly at all — no nationally representative measure of outage frequency exists, though the World Bank's Somalia Enterprise Survey, fielded between June and November 2025, collects outage frequency, duration and sales losses.

What that costs a digital service shows up at the point of care. In Mogadishu's Electronic Immunization Register, power cuts and unreliable connectivity mean staff still record on paper and upload later, so the system is not continuously online where it is used (February 2026).

Technical Capacity

The largest single improvement Somalia has recorded anywhere on the Ibrahim Index is in running a state: [Public Administration – civil registration, statistical capacity, effective administration, tax and revenue mobilisation and budgetary management](#) – gained 20.1 points over 2014-2023, the biggest movement across all sixteen sub-categories, to reach 30.1 out of 100. It is still 48th of 54, as is [Effective Administration](#) on 30.7 out of 100 for 2023, itself up 15.9 points. The direction is real; the starting point was close to nothing.

In-house build has begun to appear alongside the procurement. NIRA's Director-General says HUBIYE, the Certificate Delivery System and the eAqoonsi mobile ID were "[entirely developed by Somali engineers at NIRA](#)" – a claim about the application layer, sitting above an identity system whose [core technology and hardware come from Pakistan's NADRA](#), the primary technology partner. That is the shape of Somali technical capacity in 2026: Somali teams on the services citizens touch, foreign vendors underneath.

Two domestic technical institutions now anchor specific programmes. A [National IPv6 Center](#) hosted at Jamhuriya University supports the [national IPv6 migration \(June 2026\)](#), giving that work a base inside the country rather than in a consultancy. The national incident-response capability started smaller still, with [45 officials in SOMCIRT's first-phase training \(March 2026\)](#).

Outside government, the developer base is thin and self-organised, clustered around communities such as [Dugsiye and Somalis in Tech](#).

Cybersecurity

Somalia acquired both a cyber law and a national CERT within six weeks in early 2026. Parliament [approved the Cybersecurity Law on 26 January 2026](#), giving policy responsibility to the Ministry of Communications and Technology, technical oversight to the National Communications Authority and compliance obligations to critical-infrastructure operators. The Somalia Computer Incident Response Team, mandated by that law, became operational on 7 March 2026, opened by Prime Minister Hamza Abdi Barre to coordinate prevention, detection and response and to issue national alerts. Before it, the country had scored 37.38 out of 100 in the [ITU Global Cybersecurity Index 2024, Tier 4 of five](#).

The institutions are in place ahead of the rules they are meant to enforce. Somalia has [no adopted cybersecurity risk-management and compliance framework](#): the National Communications Authority convened a national consultation in April 2026 to build one, covering risk identification, regulatory compliance and institutional responsibilities. The Electronic Transactions and Cybercrime bills remained before Parliament, the latter having completed its first reading in December 2025, so prosecution of an incident SOMCIRT detects still rests on thinner ground than the defence of it. Breach reporting is the one obligation already in force, under [the Data Protection Act's 72-hour notification duty](#).

Capability is being bought in from abroad rather than grown. The build-out rests on [cooperation memoranda signed with Turkey on 10 February 2026 and with Malaysia and the UN Office on Drugs and Crime](#), following the EU- and German-financed D4D Initiative for Digital Government and Cybersecurity for the Horn of Africa, a EUR 3 million technical assistance programme covering Somalia alongside Kenya and Djibouti that ran to 2025. Assurance work on

the state's most sensitive system has been commissioned without reaching the public: the Ministry of Finance [tendered for a firm to assess security at NIRA headquarters and registration centres](#), and no results are in the public domain.

DPI

Data Exchange

Somalia's Auditor-General found in the 2025 annual audit that [seven government revenue and financial-management systems — business registration, e-tax, road tax, rental income tax, e-visa, non-tax e-revenue and digital financial services collection — are not integrated with the Somali Financial Management Information System](#), and a separate IT audit of the customs system published in January 2025 found [no integration between customs and the government's other revenue-collection systems](#). Behind the individual findings sits a structural one: [Somalia has no whole-of-government data exchange platform and no primary legislation establishing authority for cross-government data sharing](#), so ministries and agencies hold data in their own separate systems with no shared enterprise architecture between them.

What does cross moves point to point rather than through a shared layer. The instant payment system is [built on the ISO 20022 messaging standard](#), the one national standard in production use, but [integration of the mobile money providers into it remains outstanding, with no published date, leaving the country's dominant payment rails outside the national instant payment system](#) (July 2026).

Most of the joins that would matter are pipeline rather than plumbing. Integration of the digital civil registration system with the national ID, healthcare, immigration and education systems is [under development with UNICEF and German government support and has not been completed](#) (2025), and linking the Unified Social Registry to the identity system is [described in government and humanitarian coordination documents as a future goal](#) (October 2025). NIRA's Director General acknowledged in June 2025 that [the siloed nature of Somali government databases and the absence of interoperability standards remain a major obstacle](#).

Coordination has so far been convened rather than built. Somalia held its [first National Digital Public Infrastructure Summit in Mogadishu on 14-15 February 2026](#), bringing the Central Bank, the National Communications Authority, NIRA and the Data Protection Authority together to map interoperability across the digital estate, and NIRA opened a [National ID and Public Service Integration Working Group with UNDP in June 2026](#). The [Digital Transformation Strategy for 2025-2030](#) is meant to coordinate all of it, and there is no standalone data exchange strategy.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Around two million Somalis had registered for the national ID by April 2026, but [the eAqoonsi mobile ID app had recorded only about 50,000 downloads and digital activation still requires an in-person visit to a NIRA centre first](#). The programme is [targeting 15 million issuances by the end of 2029](#), and at one million enrolments in November 2025 NIRA acknowledged that [about 85 per cent of the population holds no formal identity document](#).

The system rests on the [National Identification and Registration Act of March 2023](#), which created NIRA and set its mandate, eligibility rules and biometric requirements; Pakistan's NADRA supplies the core identity management system and hardware. The credential is verified through the consent-based, OTP-driven HUBIYE platform, to which more than 24 services had been integrated by November 2025.

Somalia has made the ID compulsory faster than it has enrolled people. Enrolment is mandatory for all citizens, and an April 2025 prime ministerial directive requires government and private-sector institutions to integrate the ID into service delivery; it has since been required for passports from 1 September 2025, for bank accounts under a Central Bank rule of 29 July 2025, for domestic travel from 1 January 2026, for driver's licences and vehicle registration, and from March 2026 for inter-state travel. In September 2025 President Hassan Sheikh Mohamud ordered every agency and business to use the ID and called it "a national crime" to serve anyone who does not hold one — in a federation where two member states have declined to implement the federal ID at all.

Civil registration is the weaker half. Around 3.5 per cent of children under five were registered and 0.3 per cent held a birth certificate (2020), and Somalia's civil registration score on the Ibrahim Index for 2023 was 53rd of 54 African states. A Unified Digital Civil Registration Service launched in 19 districts on 10 August 2025, sending births, deaths, marriages and divorces to a central database in real time, and had reached around 30 districts and 160 linked hospitals, with more than 28,000 births registered at the point of occurrence (2025).

Digital Payments and Fintech

Somalia's national instant payment system has been live since January 2025, but the rails that carry most of the country's money are still outside it: integration of the mobile money providers into SIPS remains outstanding, with no published date (July 2026). Mobile money is worth roughly \$8bn a year, about 36 per cent of GDP, across some 650 million transactions annually, built almost entirely by private operators Hormuud and Telesom in the absence of state provision (January 2026).

SIPS launched in January 2025 as the first nationwide instant payment system, carrying instant transfers from mobile and banking apps and QR payments under a national standard, SOMQR. It is operated by the Somalia Payment Switch, a joint venture between the Central Bank of Somalia and 13 commercial banks, and it already carries person-to-person, merchant, government-to-person and person-to-government payments, with business-facing services still in development (July 2026). The Central Bank signed the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System membership agreement in March 2026 and is undertaking technical onboarding, with Somalia listed as "live soon" rather than live (June 2026).

Government payment out has almost finished going digital while government collection has not. The non-formalised, non-security wage bill fell from 36.3 per cent in 2021 to 0.03 per cent by the end of 2025, so salaries — the dominant government-to-person flow — now move almost entirely through digital channels, against a 2022 Public Financial Management Regulation requiring all public-sector payroll to be paid by electronic funds transfer. Sales tax is deducted automatically from mobile-money merchant accounts through an Electronic Tax Administration System introduced in late 2024, alongside automated road-use and rental-income tax collection, but customs duties cleared under the Somali Customs Automated System still require a manual bank receipt and cashier step (2024).

On the private side, Hormuud's EVC Plus holds GSMA Mobile Money re-certification, one of only about ten platforms worldwide to meet the standard alongside M-PESA and MTN MoMo (August 2025). Consumer protection rests on the Central Bank's Mobile Money Regulations as amended in 2021, with no comprehensive payments statute behind them.

Registries

Biometric voter registration is the register that moved: the National Independent Electoral and Boundaries Commission registered roughly 919,000 to one million voters in Mogadishu and Banadir between April and September 2025 ahead of November 2025 council elections, and about 216,000 in Galmudug ahead of a vote set for 20 July 2026, with Puntland and Jubaland outside the process. It runs on the commission's own biometric infrastructure, built by contractor NOVA GROUP, and is not integrated with the national ID system or any other government database (2025).

The business register is the oldest of the functional registers and the most used. The Ministry of Commerce and Industry has run an online business registration and licensing portal since March 2022, built with IFC and World Bank support and extended to Jubaland in 2024, which has substantially cut registration and licensing times — against a formal business base the National Bureau of Statistics counted in its 2024/25 establishment census.

The Unified Social Registry is operational and used to target beneficiaries of the Baxnaano cash-transfer programme, combining proxy means testing with a District Distress Index for geographic targeting, though it is only partially rather than fully deployed (September 2025), and linking it to the national identification system is planned but not yet operational (October 2025). The Somalia Revenue Directorate operates a digital tax administration covering both individual income taxpayers and corporate taxpayers, alongside the Somali Customs Automated System (2025).

Land is the register that does not exist. Somalia has no unified national digital land or title register: administration is split across customary Xeer, Sharia and statutory traditions, records were largely destroyed during the civil war, and only isolated municipal cadastral and GIS pilots operate, in Garowe, Bosaso and Baidoa (December 2024).

Sectoral management information systems

Somalia's Ministry of Finance was still procuring a fit-for-purpose Integrated Tax Administration System in 2025, tendering an implementation contract after years of World Bank-supported design work, leaving the existing Financial Management Information System providing only basic revenue receipting and taxpayer number generation. Where systems exist they stand apart from one another, as the Auditor-General's IT audit of the customs system in January 2025 found.

Health is the deepest deployment and still a thin one. The national platform is DHIS2, which UNICEF and the University of Oslo's HISP Centre agreed in August 2025 to strengthen under a further three-year agreement. An Electronic Immunization Register built on it assigns each vaccinated child a unique identifier, and has been piloted in 14 health facilities in Banadir region and is being scaled to more than 80 facilities nationwide (February 2026); the CaafimaadPlus digitalised data system had by 2026 expanded to more than 40 facilities across nine regions, capturing patient records on handheld devices and feeding them into the federal DHIS2 platform in real time.

Underneath the pilots the process is manual: rural primary healthcare clinics record patient data on standardised paper registers, with monthly summary forms aggregated by district health information officers into DHIS2 rather than entered at the point of service (2026).

Education is further back: the annual school census is collected on paper questionnaires by enumerators and aggregated upward before entry into the national Education Management Information System, with rural primary schools keeping enrolment and attendance records mainly on paper (2024). Justice gained a system in 2025: an Integrated Electronic Case Management System launched on 9 October 2025 with US funding and IDLO support, linking the Criminal Investigation Department, the Attorney General's Office, the Supreme Court, Benadir regional and appeal courts and Mogadishu Central Prison on one digital platform, with deployment phased rather than nationwide.

Public financial management is where the measured improvement sits: on the Ibrahim Index, Tax and Revenue Mobilisation rose 22.2 points over 2014-2023 to 34.7 out of 100, 40th of 54, and Budgetary and Financial Management 20.8 points to 37.5, 46th of 54.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Somalia scored 0.1468 on the UN E-Government Development Index for 2024, ranking 191st of 193 member states and placing it in the index's low group. What a citizen can transact online is correspondingly thin, and most of what exists is identity verification attached to an in-person service rather than a service delivered online: since June 2025 the Ministry of Transport and Civil Aviation has required a NIRA-issued national ID card to obtain a driver's licence or register a vehicle, making it the first federal body to enforce the April 2025 directive, though traffic-offence records are not exchanged with other systems.

The clearest new citizen-facing service is the Somali National Job Portal for Employment Opportunities, a centralised, domestically hosted platform through which public-sector vacancies are advertised and applied for (February 2026).

Paying the state is ahead of filing with it. The Revenue Directorate offers downloadable personal income, corporate income and withholding tax return forms for manual submission, with no electronic filing linked to the QR payment channel that already accepts tax and fee payments, while at state level Hirshabelle has replaced a manual revenue voucher reconciliation cycle of 30 to 45 days with automatic reconciliation in its digitised tax collection system (July 2026).

The plan for domestic hosting and digital service delivery is set out in the ministry's eGovernment Strategy for 2025-2029, and the National Data Centre meant to carry it was not yet operational at the responsible minister's site visit in May 2025. On trade, no timetable, budget or vendor has been stated for any of Somalia's named trade-facilitation digital systems, including the planned National Single Window (August 2026).

Governance

Legislation and regulation

Somalia's identity statute gives citizens a right to an identity credential rather than a duty to hold one: [Law No. 009 of 2023 imposes no obligation to obtain an ID and criminalises only fraud and obstruction](#), which is the ground on which a published legal reading of the September 2025 presidential proclamation ordering universal use argues that it turned a right into an obligation without legislative debate. The chain behind it runs from the [2020 civil registration law to the 2023 Act that created the National Identification and Registration Authority](#), with the identification and data-protection laws both taking effect in 2023.

Telecommunications rests on the [National Communications Law of 2017](#), which carries the statutory framework for broadband, spectrum management including TV white spaces, and universal access. Beyond it the book thins. As at December 2025 the [Electronic Transactions, Cybersecurity and Cybercrime bills](#) were all still before Parliament, the [Cybercrime Bill](#) having just completed its first reading, with none of them enacted; Parliament approved the [Cybersecurity Law](#) on 26 January 2026. A technical working group opened in June 2026 to develop a submarine-cable regulatory framework, alongside outage management and competition rules.

Personal data is the one field with a settled regime, a [cross-sector Data Protection Act](#) having been in force since [March 2023](#). Compliance with what is already on the books is a separate matter: the [2025 audit recorded 66 legal-compliance breaches by government bodies](#), including US\$18.5m of contracts awarded without following committee procedures.

Strategies, plans and policies

Somalia's governing ICT policy has expired and its successor is not adopted. The [National ICT Policy and Strategy 2019-2024](#) set the country's positions on broadband, cybersecurity, data centres and cloud services, data protection and digital payments; the [Digital Transformation Strategy for 2025-2030](#) was validated at a national multi-stakeholder workshop in October 2025 with ITU support and was still being finalised, intended to coordinate every national digital initiative, interoperability included, with no separate data exchange strategy beside it. It is drawn as a [single national framework covering education, health, agriculture and finance](#).

What the ministries have published in the interval is narrower. The Ministry of Communications and Technology issued an [eGovernment Strategy for 2025-2029](#) in August 2025, carrying the plan for domestic government hosting and digital service delivery.

Delivery is clearest where it has a named owner. Trade facilitation is coordinated by Sadaq Mohamed, National Trade Facilitation Coordinator in the Office of the Prime Minister, and the [National Trade Facilitation Committee held a two-day strategic induction and roadmap workshop in Mogadishu at the end of July 2026](#), with nineteen priority legal and policy instruments — rules of origin, competition and consumer protection, special economic zones, intellectual property — mapped and scheduled to run alongside the trade-facilitation digital systems (August 2026). Against that, [no timetable, budget or vendor has been stated for any of those systems](#).

The governing capacity these plans sit on is weak and slowly improving. Somalia scores 25.5 out of 100 for overall governance in 2023, 53rd of 54 African states, after a ten-year gain of 6.8 points, and sits below the continental average on all sixteen sub-categories, in the bottom ten on thirteen of them, and above the African average on only six of the index's 96 indicators, on a GDP per capita of USD 643.8 in 2023, 46th of 54.

Regional collaboration

Regional rules on cross-border data flows and personal data protection were approved at East African Community official level on 24 July 2026 and must still clear the Community's decision-making organs before any partner state, Somalia among them, adopts them; no adoption date has been published. Somalia is inside that process as a full EAC member since March 2024, one of the bloc's eight partner states.

The monetary track is slower. The 29th Ordinary Meeting of the EAC Monetary Affairs Committee held the single-currency target at 2031 while recording that no partner state has attained all four primary macroeconomic convergence criteria (July 2026), and the central bank's membership of the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System is signed but not yet live. Somalia signed ratification of the African Continental Free Trade Area in early August 2026, the commitment its trade-facilitation systems are being built to serve, and it belongs to COMESA, CEN-SAD and IGAD, scoring 38.5 out of 100 on regional integration in 2023, 35th of 54 and up 7.6 points over the decade.

The harder border is the internal one. Puntland and Jubbaland have declined to implement the federal national ID, and Puntland has created its own identification authority, accusing Mogadishu of overreach on data control, election influence and regional autonomy (September 2025).

Standards

The risk named in Somali analysis is not a failure to digitise but digitising the existing fragmentation, with weak coordination treated as a governance problem calling for role clarity, interoperability standards and accountability rather than more procurement (April 2026). The gap it points at is real: there is no whole-of-government data exchange platform and no shared government enterprise architecture or interoperability layer, and NIRA's own Director General acknowledged in June 2025 that siloed databases and the absence of interoperability standards remain a major obstacle.

Payments are where published standards have actually been adopted, with the instant payment system built on the ISO 20022 messaging standard, a national standardised QR code layered on it, and Hormuud's EVC Plus holding GSMA Mobile Money certification.

In trade, the official charged with delivery has set the premise that clear mandates and compatible procedures must accompany the digital systems, since automating confusion would move the same problems online (August 2026).

Data protection

In June 2026 Somalia's Data Protection Authority issued a notice under Article 32 of the Data Protection Act requiring all data controllers and processors to complete mandatory registration, and began accepting applications and issuing compliance certificates — the regulator's first nationwide compliance step.

The statute behind it, Law No. 005 of 2023, has been in force since 23 March 2023 and is grounded in Article 19 of the 2012 Provisional Constitution. It is a general cross-sector instrument, setting out lawful bases for processing, data-subject rights, data-protection impact assessment and data-protection-officer duties, and a registration requirement for "controllers of major importance", alongside cross-border transfer restrictions and breach notification duties. Article 25 gives controllers 72 hours from becoming aware of a breach likely to risk rights and freedoms to notify the Authority, and requires notice to affected individuals where the risk is high, and breaches carry fines of 2-4% of a controller's worldwide turnover.

The Authority was inaugurated on 24 February 2024 with power to issue guidelines, investigate, impose fines, register controllers and processors and receive complaints, and has since published implementation guidance and an alternative dispute resolution procedure. Its leadership is appointed by the executive. The Council of Ministers approved the regulatory framework operationalising the Act on 8 January 2026, while enforcement capacity remains thin — the Authority completed its first training of public and private institutions only in mid-2026.

Somalia imposes no data localisation requirement on personal, government, financial or critical infrastructure data, applying instead an adequacy-based cross-border transfer regime under which controllers assess protection in the receiving jurisdiction or rely on contractual safeguards or consent. Redress runs through general channels only: the constitutional privacy right and the Act's right to an effective remedy, with no judicial process specific to NIRA or the identity system. In payments, conduct duties rest on the Central Bank's Mobile Money Regulations as amended in 2021, with no comprehensive payments consumer protection statute or formal redress framework.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Media freedom is among Somalia's ten most deteriorated governance indicators, having fallen 6.7 points over 2014-2023 to 38.9 out of 100, 44th of 54 African states. Freedom of expression and belief scores 19.3 out of 100 in 2023, 49th of 54, unchanged across the decade, and digital freedom scores 39.7, 39th of 54, equally flat over the same period — the online space has neither followed the offline decline nor pulled away from it.

Consultation happens where a document needs validating rather than where a decision needs testing. The Digital Transformation Strategy went to a national multi-stakeholder workshop in October 2025, and the National Communications Authority convened a national consultation in April 2026 to develop a cybersecurity risk-management and compliance framework. Licensing has moved faster than either: Starlink's entry was fast-tracked and the company's full foreign-ownership model accepted without local-ownership conditions (2025).

Inclusion

Digital divides

On Somalia's largest network the coverage has run ahead of the handsets needed to use it: most of Hormuud's network carries 4G while a large part of its subscriber base is still on 2G or feature phones (May 2026), which makes the device rather than network reach the binding constraint on who gets online. The operator's answer is credit rather than coverage: with Get-Phone it is financing smartphones on a \$19 deposit and \$0.60 to \$1.60 a day, repaid through EVC Plus and bundled with 1GB and 40 minutes, aiming at 100,000 handsets across central and southern Somalia by the end of 2026 with Puntland and Somaliland to follow.

The lines drawn by the digital ID rollout run along connectivity and literacy. [Women, the elderly and people with disabilities are the groups most at risk of being left behind](#), which is why SMS and USSD channels have been urged as an alternative to a smartphone app whose [downloads remain a small fraction of registrations](#) (April 2026). Displacement and mobility cut across the same rollout: [a very large internally displaced population, a large nomadic one and widely missing breeder documents](#) make exclusion its central risk (June 2025).

The older divides have not moved with the technology. [Internet use remains a minority of the population](#) (2024), and Somalia's score on the Ibrahim Index's internet and computers measure [sits in the bottom quarter of the continent](#) (2023). Electricity, without which none of it works, [reaches rural households at roughly a quarter of the urban rate](#) (2023). Satellite service has been [available across the whole country since August 2025](#), from Mogadishu and Hargeisa to pastoral Shabelle, so the remaining gap in those areas is one of price rather than reach. The statutory hook for closing it, [universal access under the 2017 National Communications Law](#), has been in place throughout.

Access to services

Somalia scores [14.2 out of 100 on equal access to public services](#) and [20.1 on equal socioeconomic opportunity](#), 50th and 48th of 54 African countries, and the first of those has risen by under two points in a decade (2023). The obstacle is rarely that a service does not exist, but that obtaining it requires a document most people do not hold: [the great majority of Somalis have no formal identity document](#) (November 2025), [birth registration has been close to absent](#) (2020), and even the mobile ID app [requires an in-person visit to a NIRA centre before it can be activated](#) (April 2026) — centres still being opened district by district [in Mogadishu](#) (April 2025).

For some groups the document barrier is written into the rules. [Refugees and asylum seekers cannot open a formal bank account in Somalia, because neither the federal anti-money laundering framework nor Somaliland's 2019 AML/CFT Act recognises refugee identity documents as valid customer due diligence evidence](#); the 2015 Money Transfer Businesses customer registration regulations leave them tiered access to lower-threshold mobile money accounts, the only formal channel open to them (2022). Provision for disabled users is charitable rather than designed: a diaspora organisation [distributes speaking mobile phones to blind people in Mogadishu](#) to support mobile banking use (2025).

Where a service is reached at all, it is usually over privately built rails. [Formal banking touches a small minority of Somalis while mobile money reaches most of them](#) (2026), so government charges and [humanitarian cash alike](#) ride on operator infrastructure, and [social assistance is paid into mobile wallets](#) (2024). Cost sorts the rest. Mobile data is [among the cheaper rates in the region](#) (2025), but the satellite service that covers the places the networks do not costs [\\$390 for hardware and \\$70 a month, or \\$210 for the mini terminal](#) (August 2025), and the electricity to run any of it is [among the most expensive in Africa](#) (2023). The consequences show up in basic services: [most Somali children have received no routine vaccination](#) (2026), the gap the electronic immunization register is being scaled to close.

Technology

AI

Somalia's artificial intelligence effort sits outside government: the [National AI Center, established in October 2024](#), works on research, education and industry capacity-building rather than on putting AI into state systems. At regional level the East African Community is [developing an AI policy roadmap](#) intended to cover all eight partner states, Somalia among them, on the argument that East Africa should govern artificial intelligence as a single bloc rather than country by country; it was still under discussion as at March 2026. Somali universities sit inside the same bloc's [German-funded regional AI research and training network](#), which ran its first student cohort in 2025.

ICT Industry

Somalia's [business and competition regulation scores 13.6 out of 100 \(2023\)](#), 53rd of 54 African countries despite a ten-point rise over the decade, and the technology industry that has grown inside that environment is a wholly private one. [Hormuud and Telesom built the country's mobile money system in the absence of state provision](#), and [Hormuud's EVC Plus holds GSMA mobile money re-certification](#). New product development sits with the operators too: [Hormuud's smartphone financing scheme underwrites customers on telecom credit scoring built from SIM tenure and mobile-money spending rather than formal credit history \(May 2026\)](#). Outside the operators the domestic software [developer community is small and emerging, organised around groups such as Dugsiye and Somalis in Tech \(2023\)](#).

Innovation ecosystem

Somalia is [not among the 133 economies covered by the Global Innovation Index 2024](#), so the country carries no innovation rank or score at all. What exists on the ground is a small hub network — [iRise Hub, HarHub, Ganacsikaab, Tilmaam i-HUB and SIMAD-iLab](#), concentrated in Mogadishu, Hargeisa and Garowe (2022). Commercial tracking [records several hundred Somalia-linked startups, several dozen of which have raised outside funding](#), with fresh rounds closing in the first quarter of 2026. The public side runs through the World Bank's [SCALED-UP project](#), which supports digital entrepreneurship, digital skills and ICT sector development to 2026.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

Somalia's border management runs on [PISCES, the US-backed biometric screening system](#), which places the record of who crosses the country's frontiers on an American-supplied platform (March 2026). The same reach extends into policing: the FBI's Criminal Justice Information Services division [issued a request for information in January 2025 seeking vendors to run Somalia's police automated biometric identification system at Aden Adde International Airport](#), Mogadishu's international gateway.

American money also sits under the justice system's case file. Somalia [launched an Integrated Electronic Case Management System on 9 October 2025](#), funded by the US Bureau of International Narcotics and Law Enforcement Affairs and implemented with IDLO, linking the Criminal Investigation Department, the Attorney General's Office, the Supreme Court, the Benadir regional and appeal courts and Mogadishu Central Prison on a single digital platform; deployment is phased and does not yet run nationwide.

China activities

No Chinese-financed or Chinese-operated digital infrastructure was in place in Somalia as at August 2026.

EU activities

European public financiers are the most numerous funders of Somalia's digital sector and among the least consequential. Six of the thirteen commitments on record are European — the European Union, Germany's BMZ and GIZ, Sweden's Sida twice and the UK's FCDO — yet between them they account for only about USD 20 million of committed value, a fraction of the World Bank's (August 2026).

The European Union's own commitment, made in 2024, is [EUR 4.5 million, about USD 5 million, to the ICT Support to the Security, Justice, Governance and Accountability Project](#), supplying IT and office equipment to Somali security and justice institutions at federal level and in two to three Federal Member States so that they can digitalise their human, financial and asset management. It runs to 2028.

European support has otherwise arrived regionally rather than nationally. Somalia was one of three countries covered by the [D4D Initiative for Digital Government and Cybersecurity for the Horn of Africa](#), a EUR 3 million technical assistance programme co-financed by the European Union and Germany's BMZ that ran from 2022 to 2025, with GIZ leading e-government, Expertise France leading cybersecurity and FIIAPP leading change management; the same EUR 3 million covered Kenya and Djibouti alongside Somalia.

India activities

India had no digital infrastructure, platform or vendor presence in Somalia as at August 2026.

Gulf/UAE activities

No Gulf state or Gulf-owned operator held Somali digital infrastructure or a government platform contract as at August 2026.

Capacity

Literacy

Education is Somalia's [worst-scoring governance sub-category, at 10.0 out of 100 for 2023 and last of the 54 African states measured](#), a place it holds despite an 8.9-point rise over the preceding decade. [Enrolment scores 4.4, ranking 51st, and equality in education 8.8, ranking 53rd](#) — both among the country's ten weakest indicators of any kind — while education quality is the one component that has moved, from zero to 16.7 over the same ten years (2023).

The systems built on top of that schooling are themselves mostly unread: rural primary schools keep enrolment and attendance records on paper, and the annual school census is collected on paper questionnaires and aggregated upward before it enters the national education management information system (2024).

Training and skills

Government ICT staff completed internationally certified cybersecurity training in incident response, cloud security and auditing, run across Mogadishu and Nairobi between March and May 2026 by the National Communications Authority with the World Bank's SCALED-UP project and the African Advanced Level Telecommunications Institute. Training of this kind arrives attached to particular infrastructure programmes rather than to a skills policy: the same pattern produced the first-phase cohort of the national incident-response team (March 2026), the technical base for IPv6 migration hosted at Jamhuriya University (June 2026), and digital skills as one strand of the World Bank's SCALED-UP work alongside financial inclusion, entrepreneurship and ICT sector development.

Somalia is named among the eight member states of the East African Community's regional AI research and training network, funded by Germany's BMZ with EUR 5 million and intended to equip 50,000 young people with digital skills alongside an EAC artificial intelligence strategy for 2025-2028 (August 2026). Domestic university provision predates all of it: Mogadishu University has run a faculty of computer science and information technology since 2003.

Research institutions

Somalia gave knowledge production an institutional home in October 2024, when it established a National AI Center whose remit is research, education and industry capacity-building rather than putting artificial intelligence to work inside government systems. What sits beside it is regional rather than national: Somali universities were among those from the eight member states taking part in the 2025 pilot of the East African Community's AI research and training network, funded by Germany's BMZ with EUR 5 million and running alongside an EAC artificial intelligence strategy for 2025-2028 (August 2026).

Digitalisation

Rural digital data capture

Where the Somali state itself does the recording outside the capital, it records on paper: rural police stations keep occurrence books, station diaries, crime registers and property registers in hard copy (2025), and the Somali Police Force's Basic Recruit Curriculum trains officers in police books and forms with no digital tool anywhere in it. Health follows the same pattern. Rural primary healthcare clinics write patient data onto standardised paper registers for outpatient care, immunisation and maternal and child health, which district health information officers then aggregate into the national DHIS2 system rather than capturing it digitally at the point of service (2026). In education the annual school census is collected on paper questionnaires and aggregated upward before it reaches the national Education Management Information System, though headteachers in schools supported by a Global Partnership for Education programme have been trained to enter student and teacher data into the online EMIS directly (2024).

Digital capture that does reach rural areas arrives through programmes rather than through the line ministries. A donor-run health programme now records patient encounters on handheld devices in facilities across several regions and feeds them into the federal DHIS2 platform in real time (2026), and the Unified Digital Civil Registration Service put district registration offices in five federal member states online for births, deaths, marriages and divorces in August 2025. Agriculture has no comparable system in the field; e-agriculture has been a stated goal of the National ICT Policy and Strategy since 2019. The constraint underneath all of it is power, with rural electrification far below urban (2023).

The wider rural picture has been deteriorating on the Ibrahim Index of African Governance: Rural Land and Water Access is Somalia's most deteriorated indicator, scoring zero out of 100 in 2023 and ranking 45th of 54, while Rural Economy Support stood at 26.5 and 43rd and Rural Representation and Participation at 24.5 and 42nd, unchanged across the decade to 2023. Rural Economy is one of only two sub-categories moving against the country's overall improvement.

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The most developed digital system run by a tier of government below the national one is a revenue platform in Hirshabelle. SUMER, built by the Mogadishu firm Tabaarak ICT, collects border checkpoint revenue through a card terminal that holds the tariff schedule on the device: the officer enters vehicle type, origin and category, the terminal returns the amount due, payment moves over mobile money straight into the government account with no merchant intermediary, and a QR-coded receipt posts to a central system in real time (July 2026). Holding the tariff on the terminal is the point of it: the amount is not the officer's to set.

What it replaced was physical. Paper vouchers were carried up to 90km and keyed in by hand, a reconciliation the state's finance minister puts at 30 to 45 days and which remained incomplete, and shilling cash sat 48 hours in the treasury for conversion to dollars before deposit (July 2026). The state reports a many-fold rise in collections at equipped checkpoints in the first quarter of 2026 against 2020.

Beyond that, sub-national involvement is participation in national systems rather than systems of the states' own. Local administrations across the federal member states take part in the digital civil registration pilot in 19 districts, and the Office of the Prime Minister and the communications ministry are working to coordinate federal and state-level activity (2025). Land is the clearest case of the gap: with no unified national digital land or title register, municipal cadastral and geographic information pilots run in isolation in Garowe, Bosaso and Baidoa (2024), each a town's own arrangement rather than a tier of the state.

Data

National statistics

Somalia's capacity to run a statistical system rose 29.1 points over the decade to 2023, reaching 35.1 out of 100 and 42nd of 54 African states, the fifth most improved of the 96 indicators the Ibrahim Index tracks for the country. That is movement from close to nothing rather than arrival at a working system. The World Bank records no population

census, no agricultural census and no business census held within twenty years, as at 2023, and on the same measure no household survey, no health survey and no business survey in the ten years to 2023, alongside one labour survey and two agricultural surveys.

The gap is in collection rather than in what is made of the result. Somalia's weakest statistical performance pillar by a wide margin is data sources, scoring under 20%, while data products sit in the 50-69% band and data use in the 70-89% band (2023).

The National Bureau of Statistics has begun filling that gap with instruments of its own: its Business Establishment Census for 2024/25 identified roughly 48,000 formal business establishments. It has also been building administrative data-sharing with line ministries, convening a second Joint Data and Statistics Forum in June 2025 with over 130 government and partner representatives, which produced clearer institutional roles and improved sharing mechanisms. Users are not yet feeling it: limited data-sharing platforms is one of the two most cited barriers reported in the bureau's 2025 user satisfaction survey.

What cannot be counted also shapes how Somalia appears elsewhere: the 2024 Ibrahim Index holds no data for the country on 19 of its 96 indicators, including every one of its 16 public-perception measures, and vital statistics rest on a civil registration system whose coverage remains minimal. The rebuilding is largely externally financed, with British and African Development Bank commitments to statistical capacity running to 2026.

Open data

Five of the 23 data categories the Open Data Inventory assessed for Somalia in 2024 score zero out of ten — among them banking, energy and crime statistics — meaning nothing at all was found published to the inventory's coverage and openness criteria. At the other end, government finance is the strongest category at 6.5 out of 10, followed by price statistics, the built environment, education facilities and gender statistics at 5.5 each, with nothing reaching 7.

Across the 23 categories assessed in 2024 the mean score is 3.7 out of 10, the whole distribution squeezed between a floor of zero and a ceiling of 6.5.

The direction is upward from a near-standing start. Somalia's disclosure of public records rose 19.1 points over 2014-2023 to 22.1 out of 100, 41st of 54, and accessibility of public records rose 13.2 points to 13.7, 44th of 54, leaving both in the bottom quarter of African states after a decade of the fastest improvement either measure has seen.

Where public information does reach the page it comes mostly through audit. The Auditor-General's 2025 annual audit covered 30 projects across 22 bodies financed by the World Bank, African Development Bank and IMF, together 60.1% of the national budget, and published breaches of legal and procurement procedure by government bodies alongside them. The limits show in the same document: the audit could not independently verify the revenue share reported from the Mogadishu port and airport concession, because the underlying records were not available to it. The Central Bank is the steadier publisher, issuing audited financial statements under IFRS with an independent opinion, and a statistical bulletin each June.

Use of satellite data

No national programme for the state's use of earth-observation or geospatial data was in place as at August 2026.

Finance

New investments

No other institution comes close to the World Bank: five of the thirteen digital-sector commitments on record are its own, and about USD 328 million of the roughly USD 354 million committed, around 88 per cent of the Somalia-only total once regional programmes are set aside (August 2026). The thirteen were announced between 2015 and August 2026 and run to 2028, with about USD 189 million for Somalia alone and the rest in three regional programmes. All of it is public money – four concessional loans, every one the World Bank's, six grants and three technical assistance operations, with no equity, commercial lending or guarantees. European financiers hold six of the thirteen but only about USD 20 million of the value (August 2026). Statistical capacity is the largest destination by number, taking four, ahead of government systems with three.

The [SCALED-UP credit of USD 31 million, approved in March 2019](#), and its [USD 70 million additional financing of June 2021](#) run to 2026 across digital skills, financial services and job creation, and digital ID is [a major pillar of the World Bank's SPRING initiative, a programme of over USD 100 million](#) (December 2025). Somalia is [one of two sovereign borrowers, with South Sudan, under the USD 162 million Eastern Africa Regional Digital Integration Project approved in May 2023](#). Two earlier Bank operations closed in 2023: [a USD 50 million public financial management project](#) that rolled IFMIS out across the federal government, Puntland and Somaliland, and [a USD 15 million trust-funded grant](#) that built the telecom policy and regulatory environment.

Everyone else works at a tenth of that scale. The European Union committed in 2024 [EUR 4.5 million \(about USD 5 million\) of IT equipment](#) to security and justice institutions to 2028; Sweden funds [SEK 45 million \(about USD 5 million\) for the DHIS2 national health information system to 2026](#) and has approved [SEK 20.5 million for the IMF's Somalia Country Fund for 2023-2027](#); the UK [GBP 3,312,013 \(about USD 5 million\) for statistical capacity to 2026](#); and the African Development Bank [XDR 3.0 million \(about USD 4 million\) of statistics work to 2026](#).

MoUs and other agreements

The European framework Somalia signed for digital government and cybersecurity closed in 2025: the [D4D Initiative for Digital Government and Cybersecurity for the Horn of Africa](#), a EUR 3 million technical assistance programme co-financed by the European Union and Germany's BMZ, ran from 2022 and covered Somalia alongside Kenya and Djibouti, with GIZ leading on e-government, Expertise France on cybersecurity and FIIAPP on change management. What has been signed since is cooperation rather than money: [Somalia's cybersecurity build-out rests on partnerships with Turkey, Malaysia and the UN Office on Drugs and Crime](#) (March 2026).

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